

Chapter 34 - Part 2

After Sun Meirou left, Xu Qingzhu closed the door. When she turned around, she saw Liang Shi holding Little Bell's hand, standing in the middle of the road, looking at her with a very serious and solemn expression.

Xu Qingzhu's heart suddenly jumped: "What are you doing? You scared me."

"No." Liang Shi chuckled lightly, teasing: "How can you be so timid?"

Xu Qingzhu tucked the hair falling by her face behind her ear, pretending to walk back casually: "Mind your own business?"

She had just been thinking—was she being indirectly urged to have children?

"Was Second Sister-in-law just indirectly urging us to have children?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu: "...?"

She widened her eyes looking at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi asked in confusion: "What's wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu was silent for a few seconds, then shook her head: "Nothing."

She simply hadn't expected them to be so in sync sometimes.

"Don't take what my second sister-in-law said to heart." Liang Shi clarified: "I know your thoughts, I won't force you to have children."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow looking at her: "What thoughts do I have?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She glanced at Little Bell and decided to swallow all her words.

Children this age already know how to repeat things. If she went back to the old mansion and directly said that Auntie and Aunt-in-law wanted to divorce, that would be something.

Liang Shi felt that she probably wouldn't have good days after that.

Not to mention how Liang Xinhe would condemn her, just with Qiu Zimin's attitude of wanting to match her up with Zhou Yi'an, she estimated that the first day she went to get divorced, the second day she would receive a life-threatening phone call.

Better forget it.

"Auntie, Aunt-in-law." Little Bell looked up, asking innocently: "Are you two quarreling?"

Xu Qingzhu & Liang Shi: "..."

The two exchanged glances and denied simultaneously: "No."

Liang Shi crouched down, stroking Little Bell's head: "How could Auntie and Aunt-in-law quarrel? We were just chatting."

"But when my dad and mom quarrel, they use this kind of rhetorical questions." Little Bell, despite her young age, already knew about rhetorical questions. She pouted: "My dad would say: What did I do? Did I do something wrong? Are you unhappy?"

She imitated Liang Xinhe's tone about eighty percent accurately, especially the rising intonation at the end, which was quite impressive.

This made both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu laugh, finding her clever and mischievous.

However, Liang Shi was afraid she would repeat things like this when she went back, so she patiently explained her and Xu Qingzhu's behavior just now: "This is just our unique way of getting along. Just like how your dad talks to your mom like that, he's not quarreling with mom either, he's just asking if what he did was reasonable. Every couple has their own unique way of communicating, so you shouldn't make wild guesses, okay?"

Little Bell seemed to understand but not quite: "Okay."

After Liang Shi finished speaking, she noticed Xu Qingzhu staring at her meaningfully. That look seemed to say—go ahead and make things up, I'll just quietly watch you make things up.

Liang Shi: "..."

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Xu Qingzhu had been very busy recently. Originally, she was supposed to work on the autumn new product launch proposal in the morning and meet with Sally, Cherry, and Dr. Gu¹ in the afternoon. But since Little Bell rarely came to visit, she didn't feel right going directly to the study and leaving Little Bell there alone.

In the entire Liang family, the easiest people to talk to were Liang Xinhe and Sun Meirou.

So loving the house and its crowd², Xu Qingzhu would also be very good to Little Bell.

Liang Shi and Little Bell were playing a small game—Snake.

She took her laptop and sat on the sofa to work on the proposal. Little Bell was very considerate and said: "Aunt-in-law, you can go busy with work. I'll just play with Auntie!"

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "Then wouldn't I be a poor host?"

"It's okay!" Little Bell said: "You can finish your work quickly and then play with me!"

"My mom says you can't disturb other people's work, that's immoral." Little Bell said with conviction: "So when dad works at home, I never ask him to play with me."

"Little Bell is so good." Liang Shi praised gently.

It had to be said that Sun Meirou had raised Little Bell very well.

Cute appearance, soft and adorable personality, well-mannered, not naughty, and didn't make unreasonable demands.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and couldn't help pinching her face: "But I want to accompany you. You two don't need to mind me, I'll be done soon."

She had already done part of it last night after coming home, plus what she did just now, she was almost finished.

Little Bell nodded: "Okay, then we'll wait for you."

After that, she whispered to Liang Shi: "Let's be quiet and not disturb Aunt-in-law."

Liang Shi found her quite mature for her age, but also listened to her suggestion.

For a while, in the spacious room, there was only the sound of Xu Qingzhu typing on the keyboard.

She was very focused when she entered work mode. Little Bell was holding her panda doll, squishing and kneading it in her hands.

Seeing the little one was really bored, Liang Shi found a string from the drawer, tied both ends together to make a loop around her hands, and started playing cat's cradle³.

Little Bell had naturally never seen this kind of thing, let alone played it.

Liang Shi put the string on her hands first and made the first move.

Little Bell's eyes lit up with surprise. She wanted to squeal with delight but stopped herself in time, pressing her lips together and not daring to speak. She looked a bit pitiful like that. After a while, she finally managed to suppress her voice, then whispered to Liang Shi: "Auntie, that's so magical!"

"There's more magic to come." Liang Shi said confidently.

She had Little Bell pull her fingers out, then hooked the strings from her own hands one by one onto Little Bell's hands, then had her spread them out, perfectly recreating the previous pattern. Liang Shi reached out her fingers again, her nimble fingers moving gracefully, and when it returned to her hands, it was a different pattern again.

Little Bell: "!"

Her eyes were completely transfixed. Moreover, she was quite perceptive—this time she actively extended her fingers, letting Liang Shi recreate the string pattern on her hands. She wanted to see other patterns too.

After doing this twice, Little Bell untangled the string and whispered: "Auntie, can you teach me?"

Liang Shi nodded, smiling gently: "Of course."

When Liang Shi smiled at Little Bell, the corners of her mouth curved up just right, her eyes crinkled, and she smiled so gently and beautifully.

Xu Qingzhu stole a glance at them during her busy work but suddenly froze.

At that moment, it was as if she saw a gentle spring breeze.

How should she put it?

When she smiled, it was like a spring breeze caressing her face. The side she showed seemed to be adjusted to the perfect angle—no matter how you looked at it, it was very gentle, as if shrouded in a hazy light, with early autumn's light and shadow falling on her.

Liang Shi whispered to Little Bell: "Loop it around from here, don't move this string, yes, just this finger."

Her tone was gentler than a kindergarten teacher's, even like a childish voice.

It was somewhat similar to the tone she used when acting spoiled that night when she was drunk.

Inexplicably, the memory returned to that night when she was drunk.

Liang Shi lay there, her long hair covering her face, making her uncomfortable even in sleep. Especially when strands brushed across her nose, she frowned and murmured: "Mm~"

Xu Qingzhu lifted her hand to tuck her long hair behind her ear, revealing that face which was bright and beautiful but not overly flashy. Her nose bridge was high, her nostrils small. She breathed lightly, even the tone changed, as if she had suffered some grievance.

At that moment, bewitched by something unknown, Xu Qingzhu raised her hand, her fingers gently stroking her forehead, the space between her brows, smoothing out the furrow there. Her slender fingers moved downward from her nose bridge to her lips. Her lips were full, the lip pearls⁴ very pronounced, but because she hadn't drunk water after getting drunk, they appeared dry and cracked.

So her fingers gently brushed across her lips, lightly resting on her lip pearl.

Liang Shi seemed to sense something, half-opened her eyes, but quickly closed them again. Xu Qingzhu was startled and was about to withdraw her hand, but her finger touched the tip of her extended tongue.

The tongue tip was moist and warm, enveloping her finger in an instant.

Liang Shi's movements were gentle, yet like eating something, with a leisurely rhythm. Her teeth lightly grazed Xu Qingzhu's finger, seeming to bite but without applying force, just gentle contact.

Xu Qingzhu didn't feel disgusted by her touch, but rather seemed bewitched.

That was the first time Xu Qingzhu realized how nimble a person's tongue could be.

But then, she bit Xu Qingzhu hard, the pain instantly sobering her up.

That night's scene seemed covered with a layer of gray in her memory. She had clearly been forcing herself to forget, but inappropriately remembered it again, especially the warm, moist sensation, which could perfectly overlap with Liang Shi's current image.

Especially when she smiled.

"Aunt-in-law." Little Bell's voice pulled Xu Qingzhu's scattered thoughts back: "What are you thinking about?"

Xu Qingzhu snapped back: "Nothing..."

Little Bell pouted: "You were just staring at Auntie the whole time. You really like Auntie too much."

Xu Qingzhu: "...?"

"You don't even look at me." Little Bell said sourly: "Is Auntie prettier than me?"

She looked at Liang Shi and snorted lightly: "Auntie seems a little prettier than me, but when I grow up, I'll definitely be prettier than her!"

Liang Shi laughed: "Right, right, when you grow up, you'll be the most beautiful woman in the world."

"Then why does Aunt-in-law look at you and not at me?" Little Bell thought for a moment: "Is this what they call 'beauty is in the eye of the beholder'?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

This was getting more and more ridiculous.

"I wasn't." Xu Qingzhu denied strongly: "Aunt-in-law was just thinking about something and happened to look in Auntie's direction."

Liang Shi nodded in agreement: "Right, didn't we agree not to disturb Aunt-in-law? Let's be quiet."

Little Bell shrugged helplessly, her tone resigned: "Fine, whatever you adults say. Adults always like to lie to children anyway."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"No." Liang Shi said: "As an adult, I don't lie."

"Then do you like Aunt-in-law?" Little Bell thought she was whispering to Liang Shi: "My teacher said that only people who really like each other get married, but you seem very afraid of Aunt-in-law."

Liang Shi: "..."

She coughed lightly: "That's not fear."

Little Bell looked up: "Then what is it?"

"Besides, where do I seem afraid of her?" Liang Shi stubbornly maintained her position: "We're equals, there's no question of being afraid or not."

"Then why don't you dare say no to anything Aunt-in-law says?" Little Bell asked.

Liang Shi: "..."

Wasn't that because the system forced her to?

Once she had just lightly said no, and the system added misfortune points to her, followed by misfortune punishment.

She could only say that children were too young and didn't understand the dangers of society yet.

Xu Qingzhu, having heard Little Bell's words, also looked at Liang Shi with interest.

Footnotes:

¹ Dr. Gu: A doctor character mentioned in the story

² Loving the house and its crow: A Chinese idiom meaning to love someone and by extension love everything associated with them

³ Cat's cradle: A string game played by creating various patterns with a loop of string

⁴ Lip pearls: The fuller, more prominent part of the lips, often the center of the lower lip